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Authenticity

Armor Aesthetics and Decoration

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1. Definition and general requirements

Armors and weapons aesthetics are very important for the fighters' appearance and sports representation. The development of our sport will be easier with well-maintained and properly finished armor and weapons. Crafting armor and its parts is a process mostly made by hand with the help of different hand tools such as hammers and files, even during the surfacing process and polishing. Thus, it is not rare to find such traces on artifacts, even in the corners of a highly polished armor.

1.1. The following aesthetics are allowed:

- Matte polish (see page 4)
- Satin Polish (see page 7)
- Mirror Polish (see page 9)
- Blackening and Bluing (see page 11)

1.2. All types of aesthetics must respect the following requirements

- Be based on historical sources.
- Be homogenous regarding the whole set of armor: it is not allowed to mix different aesthetics in the same armor set unless specifically written in the specific requirements.
- The steel surface does not present strong forging remains, big filing traces, and modern grinding marks.
- Must be properly polished, any highly unpolished armor part is denied.
- Must be free of rust.

1.3. Decoration

An armor can be decorated with different methods, such as

- etching
- engraving
- plating and gilding

Helmets can be decorated with the medieval spirit, with crest, torse, burlets or orle for example.

Example of burlet:

Picture from Age of Craft ©

1.4. Painted armor

As the topic of painted armors is very controversial among armor experts, historical sources can’t stand a clear position about painted armor. We have historical sources for late-15th century helmets (mainly Sallets) but nothing relevant for the 14th century nor for armor parts. Therefore, any painted armor metal part, metal buckler or weapon is **denied**.

2. Matte Polish

2.1. Matte polish definition and sources

A basic polishing method, widely used during the Middle Ages. Its appearance is flat and gray, and subtle marks from the polishing process are still visible. A utilitarian finish that hides scratches and holds a protective oil film well. The basic and most common finish is the matte polish. It is recommended for all types of 14th and 15th century armor and weapons.

It is **approved** for 14th-century, Transitional armors and 15th-century armors.

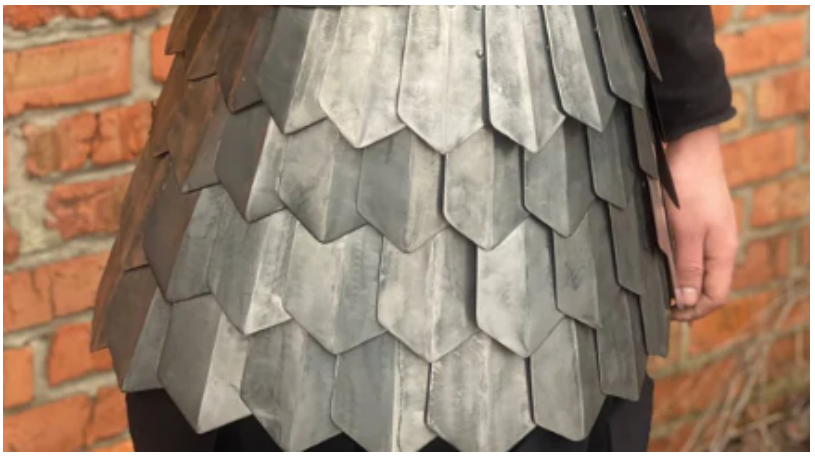
Armet, on display at the Metropolitan Museum of Arts (MET) - 1440 - New York (USA)

2.2. Specific requirements

- The whole armor or weapon must be matte polished.
- It is **denied** to have an armor set mixing matte polish with other aesthetics.
- Matte polish can be used with other decoration techniques, such as etching, engraving, gilding or plating.

2.3. Examples of Approved finishes

Picture from Medieval Extreme ©



Picture from Master Uley ©

Acceptable grinder marks

2.4. Examples of Denied finishes

Excessive rust

Unpolished weapons

Unpolished

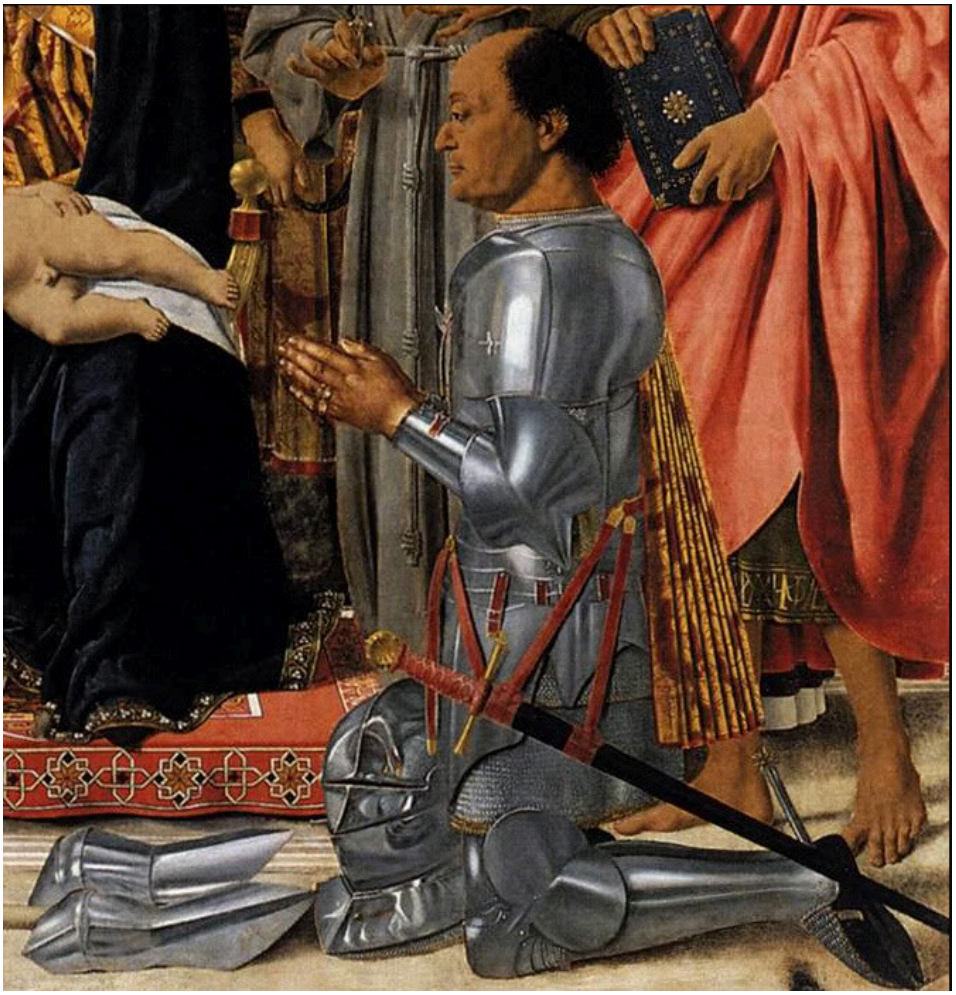
Picture from The Medieval Things ©

3. Satin Polish

3.1. Definition and sources

Satin polish has a semi-reflective surface with a subdued sheen, the polishing marks are small and only visible upon close inspection. A practical polishing method that balances functionality with a refined appearance. Armors are polished with multiple grinding grits to obtain an intermediary reflective finish. It is not as shiny as mirror polishing.

It is **approved** for 14th-century, Transitional armors and 15th-century armors.



Montefeltro Altarpiece by Piero della Francesca - 1472 - Italy
Note: the helmet in this art is mirror polished

3.2. Specific requirements

- The whole armor must be satin polished or a mix of satin and mirror polished.
- It is **denied** to have an armor set mixing matte polishing parts with satin polishing parts.
- It is **denied** to have an armor set mixing black/blued polishing parts with satin polishing parts.
- Satin polish can be used with other decoration techniques, such as etching, engraving, gilding or plating.

3.3. Examples of Approved finishes

Pictures from Master Uley ©

Picture from Black Dog Armoury ©

4. Mirror Polish

4.1. Mirror polish definition and sources

A late-period polishing technique that gained popularity in the 15th century. Metal plates are polished with progressively finer grit until polishing marks are not visible, resulting in a reflective sheen. This finish requires high maintenance to keep it looking its best. Armors are polished with multiple grinding grits reaching into the 1000 grid to obtain a beautiful reflective finish.

It is **approved** for 14th-century, Transitional armors and 15th-century armors..

Sigismund von Tirol

Armor of Sigismund von Tirol, Kunsthistorisches Museum Wien - 1484 - Austria

4.2. Specific requirements

- The whole armor must be satin polished or a mix of satin and mirror polished.
- It is **denied** to have an armor set mixing black/blued polishing parts with mirror polishing parts.
- Mirror polish can be used with other decoration techniques, such as etching, engraving, gilding or plating.

4.3. Examples of Approved finishes

Pictures from Master Uley ©

Pictures from J. Amiot ©

5. Blackening and Bluing

5.1. Blackening and Bluing definition and sources

Finishing method appearing in the mid-15th century sources, the metal plates are carefully heated to high temperatures to obtain a black or blue finish by treating the steel with oils.

It is **approved** for 15th-century armors.
It is **denied** for 14th-century and Transitional armors.

Acceptable methods of blackening/Bluing are as followed:

- **Temperature Bluing**: The metal plates are carefully heated to adequate temperatures to obtain a blue oxide finish on the surface of the steel.
- **Oil Blackening**: This technique involves applying oils, such as linseed oil, to steel, which is then baked in an oven or applied to heated steel at relatively low temperatures. The process results in a deep black, protective finish. However, it requires regular touch-ups to maintain its appearance and protective qualities.
- **Chemical blackening/bluing**: Modern chemicals normally intended for use on firearms are permitted for armor. Hot-blue treatment is preferred, as it results in a deeper and more durable finish, but be mindful of how this could affect heat-treated steel. Cold-blue can be repeatedly applied to darken the surface of the steel and also to touch up hot-blued steel.

Greenwich Armour replica (1595) Plates formed by Robert MacPherson & Jeff Wasson, decoration and finishing by Chris Gilman

A

B

C

A: 'Georgsaltar' (Meister der Georgslegende), Köln, Wallraf-Richartz-Museum - 1460-1465 - Germany
B: Armet, German - 1550 - Metropolitan Museum of Arts
C: Foot combat armor, Royal Armouries 1591 - England

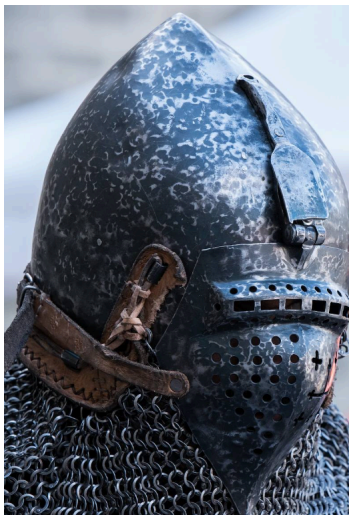
5.2. Specific requirements

- The whole armor must be of the same method of blackening/bluing.
- It is **denied** to have an armor set mixing black/blued polishing parts with other aesthetics.
- Blackening/bluing finish can be used with other decoration techniques, such as etching, engraving, gilding, or plating.
- It is **denied** to use paint to reproduce a black/blued finish.

5.3. Examples of Approved Finishes

Pictures from Master Uley ©

5.4. Examples of Denied Finishes



Unpolished helmet, trying to imitate proper blackening.
14th century helmets that can't have blackening finish.

Pictures from The Medieval Things ©

6. Decorations

6.1. Definition and sources

Armors were often decorated with different methods to display the owner's status. The following decoration methods are documented by historical sources: etching, engraving, plating and gilding. Helmets were decorated with fabric or metal elements such as crest, burlet, torse and orle.

It is **approved** for 14th-century armors, Transitional armors and 15th-century armors.

Sir William Phelip, Lord Bardolph - 1441 - England

Late 14th century, MET Museum

BL Royal 20 C VII Chroniques de France ou de St Denis - 1380/1400 - France

6.2. Specific requirements

Decoration must be based on historical sources. It is allowed to combine different decorations in a coherent way. Any decoration must not represent any offensive symbols, words, or sentence of any type. All political messages must not be used as decoration on armor and weapons. Any logo must be stylized to reach the middle-ages aesthetics and designs.

6.3. The following decorations techniques are allowed:

- **Etching**: It is **allowed** to etch historical symbols and written words with etching techniques. Armor parts and weapons can be decorated this way.

- **Engraving**: It is **allowed** to engrave historical symbols and written words with engraving techniques. Engraving can be done by hand or mechanically. Armor parts and weapons can be decorated this way.

- **Plating**: It is **allowed** to decorate the edges of an armor part with metal plates. The following materials can be used:
  - Copper
  - Brass
  - Gold
  - Silver
  - And any other metal that can be documented by historical sources.

- **Gilding**: It is **allowed** to use gilding as a decoration on armor and weapons. The following materials can be used:
  - Copper
  - Brass
  - Gold
  - Silver
  - And any other metal that can be documented by historical sources.

- **Helmet decorations**: it is allowed to decorate a helmet in the medieval spirit. It must be based on historical sources. Any textile or leather part must conform with the Textiles and Leather document.

6.4. Examples of Approved Decorations

Pictures from The Medieval Things ©

6.5. Examples of Denied Decorations

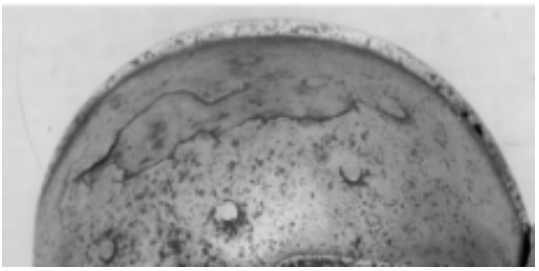
Painted helmets

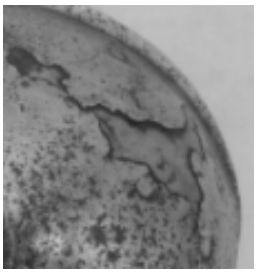
Pictures from The Medieval Things ©

7. Repairs

7.1. Definition and sources

Armors were sometimes repaired to increase its durability. In the Middle Ages, the most common way to repair an armor was to rivet a metal plate from beneath. From a buhurt point of view, it will be important to respect period techniques for visible repairs. It is **approved** for 14th-century armors, Transitional armors, and 15th-century armors.





7.2. Specific requirements

- Visible repairs must be executed with period techniques, for example with a riveted patch installed on the inside of the armor part and riveted.
- Repairs must be clean and not dangerous for other equipment elements.
- Any modern reparation is allowed if properly concealed. Any type of welding must be grinded/filed and polished on the outside.

8. Change log

Below, we will keep track of all the changes made over the lifetime of this document. This way, all our members can see how the documents are changing over time.

11-Nov-2024: -Add
Document has been created